



Wrecker-in-chief: Shami took 24 wickets in seven matches at an average of 10.70 at the 2023 World Cup in India. VIJAY SONEJI

believe in that. You should not forget your goals or targets, and you should always be loyal to your sport. I have seen people who struggled despite having enough talent, simply due to a lack of direction. So, if someone overcomes the odds and comes far, it is important to stay connected to his roots, and I am trying to do that," he says, with a smile, after receiving the award from the chairman of the jury and former India captain Sunil Gavaskar, whom he fondly refers to as 'Paaji'.

The pace ace he reveals that his target for the year is already set in stone—to guide India to title glory in the T20 World Cup, scheduled in June in the United States of America and

the West Indies.

India came close to breaking its ICC title jinx last year, reaching the final of the ODI World Cup before falling to Australia. Shami played a key role in the campaign, emerging as the top wicket-taker of the tournament with 24 scalps.

While he has been out of action in the ongoing Test series against England due to an injury, Shami believes 'playing games with his mind' and having plans according to the situation have been the key to his success.

"I don't keep specific goals. I change my plans according to the situation and adapt. It is important to be open to going with your recent circumstances, fitness, and other elements to make the whole package. And I do just that. I play games with my mind and see how I feel," Shami tells Sportstar.

In the ODI World Cup, India's pace

battery, comprising Shami, Jasprit Bumrah, and Mohammed Siraj, asserted dominance. Shami believes the change did not happen overnight.

"What people got to see in the 2023 World Cup is the product of seven-eight years of hard work. That effort built confidence and trust, which then came through in how we performed.

"The connection and faith the unit has in each other are why this pace battery has become this potent," Shami says, adding with a smile, "Hopefully the pace battery continues to run successfully for more time and finds more success."

On Indian surfaces, where conditions tend to favour spinners and batters, the task is challenging for fast bowlers. However, in recent years, a collaborative effort between the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) and the team